



APEX

Drawdown Zero V12

User Guide

MetaTrader 5 Expert Advisor · XAUUSD (Gold) H1 · Version 12.47

Four trading modes: Discipline · Growth · High-Frequency · FTMO challenge

Trading involves substantial risk of loss. Backtest results are hypothetical and do not guarantee future results.

1. What the EA does

Apex Drawdown Zero is a rules-based Expert Advisor for MetaTrader 5, built and tested for **XAUUSD (gold) on the H1 chart**. Every trade has a stop loss and a take profit from the moment it is opened, and a risk firewall limits how much the account can lose in a day and overall.

It trades two strategies, each in its own position slot:

- **01 Opening range.** Each day the EA builds a range from the first hours of the session and trades the breakout, the false break (sweep) or the retest out of it.
- **02 Trend pullback.** When gold is trending, it buys a dip to the 20 EMA (or sells a rally in a downtrend) on the candle that resumes the trend. Gold only.

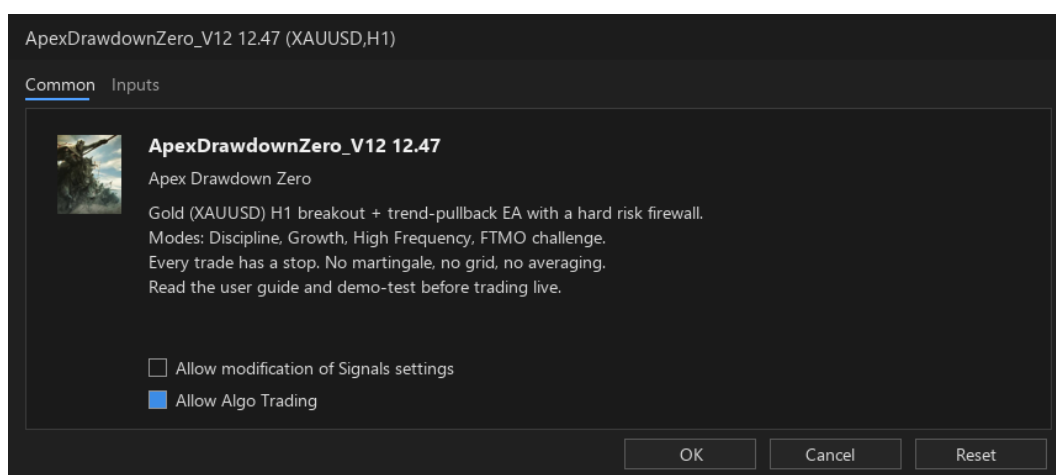
No martingale, no grid, no averaging down, no hedging tricks. A losing trade is closed at its stop. Position size is a fixed percentage of the balance.

What to expect

- Roughly **23–28 trades per month** on gold in the default mode (77–93 in High-Frequency mode).
- Several days a month with no trade are normal — the EA waits for its setups.
- Trades can go into profit and come back. Part of each position is closed at 1R and the stop moves to break-even; the rest is left to reach the target. This was tested against trailing stops, which cut profits.
- Choppy, trendless months happen. In September 2026 (to the 23rd) the EA was roughly flat.

2. Installation

Step	What to do
1	Copy ApexDrawdownZero_V12.ex5 into your terminal's MQL5\Experts folder (File → Open Data Folder). Restart MT5 or right-click Expert Advisors → Refresh.
2	Copy the .set preset files into MQL5\Presets .
3	Open an XAUUSD H1 chart. Your broker's gold symbol may be named GOLD, XAUUSD.m, etc. — that is fine.
4	Drag the EA onto the chart. In the Common tab tick Allow Algo Trading . Use Load in the Inputs tab to pick a preset, or keep the defaults.
5	Press the Algo Trading button in the MT5 toolbar so it turns green.
6	Check the dashboard shows MONITORING in green. If it says TRADING DISABLED, step 4 or 5 is missing.



The Common tab when you attach the EA. **Allow Algo Trading** must be ticked.

Requirements

- MetaTrader 5 and a broker offering XAUUSD. The EA skips new entries while the spread is above 350 points (MaxSpreadPoints).
- Keep the terminal running: a VPS is recommended. The EA must be online to manage its trades.
- **Server time:** the EA was tested on a GMT+2 / GMT+3 server (most MT5 brokers). If your broker uses another time zone, move FirstEntryHour and LastEntryHour so they still cover the London and New York sessions.
- Tested with a \$10,000 account. Smaller accounts work while 1% risk still allows the broker's minimum lot (0.01).

3. Trading modes

Choose one with the **TradingMode** input. The strategies are the same; the size, speed and safety rules differ.

Mode	For	Risk per trade	Safety limits	Typical activity
DISCIPLINE (default)	Personal accounts, steady growth	1%	Stops for the day at -3%; stops completely at -10% from the equity peak	~23–28 trades/month
AGGRESSIVE GROWTH	Fast compounding; accepts deeper drawdowns	3% (GrowthRiskPercent)	Day -10%; total -35%	Same trades, 3× size
HIGH FREQUENCY	Traders who want many trades	0.35%	Day -8%; total -10%	77–93 trades/month (M15 logic)
FTMO	Prop-firm challenges (FTMO-style rules)	Up to 2%, reduced automatically near the limits	Built around the firm's own daily and maximum-loss rules; stops at the target	Stops when the phase target is reached

Do not raise GrowthRiskPercent above 3%. In testing, 4% earned no more than 3% in the difficult year and 5% drove the account into its 35% loss limit, where the EA stops trading.

Markets

Symbol	Status
XAUUSD (gold)	Primary market. All four modes. Trend pullback runs on gold only.
EURUSD	Supported in DISCIPLINE mode (opening range + New York session). Not in High-Frequency mode.
EURJPY	Preset included; not yet validated in the current tests.
XAGUSD, GBPUSD, USDJPY, indices	Not recommended. These lost money in testing. The EA prints a warning.

4. FTMO challenge mode

FTMO mode follows the rules of a standard two-step prop-firm challenge (profit target, maximum daily loss, maximum loss, minimum trading days) and stops a safety margin before each limit.

What it does	Why
Stops trading and closes everything when the closed balance reaches the phase target	Once passed, the challenge cannot be given back. It checks the balance after commission, not just equity.
Guards the firm's maximum loss as a fixed floor under your starting balance and stops 1% above it	Prop firms measure from the initial balance, not from your highest point.
Guards the firm's daily loss (from the day's starting balance, floating losses included) and stops 1% before it	The daily rule is the one most challenges are lost on.
Makes each trade smaller as you approach a limit	A losing streak shrinks the size instead of breaching the rule.
After the target, places one tiny open-and-close trade per day until 4 trading days are reached	Covers the minimum-trading-days rule.

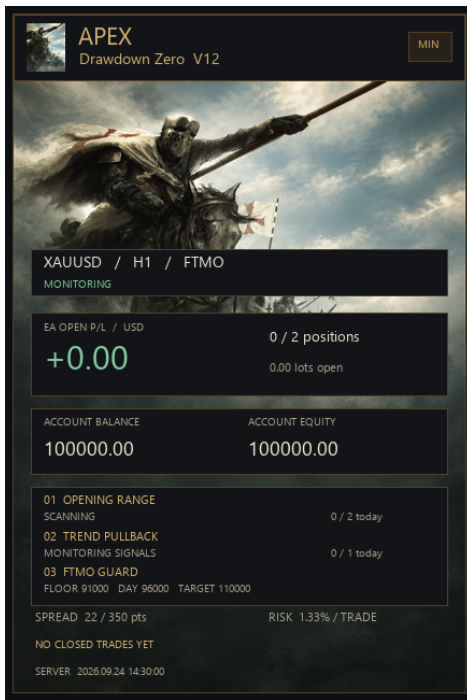
How to run a challenge

	Phase 1 (+10%)	Phase 2 (+5%)
Preset	ApexV12_FTMO_Mode_Phase1.set	ApexV12_FTMO_Mode_Phase2.set
Challenge account size	Your challenge size , e.g. 100000	The new account's size , e.g. 100000
Everything else	Leave as in the preset	Leave as in the preset

Always type your account size into "Challenge account size". If you leave it at 0, the EA uses the balance when it is first attached and remembers it — which is wrong if you attach it to an account that has already moved, or start a new account on the same terminal. To clear the memory: press F3 in MT5 and delete the variables starting with ADZ12_ftmo.

- For more margin and a slower pace, use **ApexV12_FTMO_Mode_Phase1_Safe.set**.
- If your firm's limits differ, change Firm's maximum loss, Firm's maximum daily loss and Phase target in group 2 to match its current rulebook. Always check the rules before starting.
- Once funded, set Phase target to 0 so the EA keeps trading.

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5. The dashboard

Header — MIN hides the panel; SHOW brings it back.

Status — symbol, timeframe and mode. Green MONITORING means it is live. If a safety limit has stopped trading, the reason is shown here (a passed target appears in gold).

Open P/L — profit or loss of the EA's open trades, positions and lots.

Balance / Equity — your account figures.

Engines — 01 Opening range and 02 Trend pullback, with their state and today's trade count. 03 shows the FTMO floors and target in FTMO mode, or the daily result and drawdown in the other modes.

Footer — current spread, the actual risk the next trade will use, closed-trade statistics and server time.

6. Settings

Settings are in eight numbered groups. Groups 1–3 are the ones most buyers change; everything else is best left at its tested default.

Setting (group)	Default	What it does
Trading mode (1)	Discipline	Choose Discipline, Growth, High Frequency or FTMO — see section 3.
Risk per trade % (1)	1.0 / 3.0 / 0.35	Risk for Discipline / Growth / High Frequency. Do not raise Growth above 3.
Challenge account size (2)	0	FTMO mode: your challenge size. Always fill it in.
Phase target % (2)	10	FTMO mode: 10 for phase 1, 5 for phase 2, 0 when funded.
Caution near limits (2)	2.5	FTMO mode: 3 trades more cautiously near the limits (slower, more margin).
Stop for the day at this % loss (3)	3.0	Daily loss limit in Discipline mode.
Stop the EA at this % drawdown (3)	10.0	Maximum drawdown from the equity peak in Discipline mode.
Close all on Friday at this server hour (3)	0 (off)	Set to 21 to be flat over the weekend.
Trend pullback strategy (4)	Auto	Auto = on for gold in Discipline, Growth and FTMO modes.
First entry hour / No new entries from (5)	8 / 20	Server hours when new trades may open.
Magic number (5)	26070302	Change only if you run a second copy on the same symbol.

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Common Inputs

Variable	Value
=== 1. Trading mode ===	
Trading mode	Discipline - 1% risk, steady (default)
Risk per trade % - Discipline mode	1.0
Risk per trade % - Growth mode (max 3 recommended)	3.0
Risk per trade % - High Frequency mode	0.35
Symbol preset	Auto-detect symbol (recommended)
=== 2. FTMO / prop-firm mode (TradingMode = FTMO) ===	
Challenge account size (always fill in, e.g. 100000)	0.0
Phase target % (10 = phase 1, 5 = phase 2, 0 = funded)	10.0
Firm's maximum loss % of initial balance	10.0
Firm's maximum daily loss % of initial balance	5.0
Stop this many % before either firm limit	1.0
Firm's minimum trading days	4
Maximum risk per trade %	2.0
Caution near limits (2.5 = tested default, 3 = safer)	2.5
=== 3. Risk firewall ===	
Enable risk firewall	true
Stop for the day at this % loss (0 = off)	3.0
Stop the EA at this % drawdown from peak (0 = off)	10.0
Emergency close if equity drops this % intraday (0 = off)	5.0
Stop for the day once up this % (0 = off)	0.0
Close open trades when a limit is hit	true
Close all on Friday at this server hour (0 = off, e.g. 21)	0
=== 4. Strategies ===	
Trend pullback strategy	Auto - gold only (recommended)
New York session strategy	Auto - FX pairs only (recommended)
Maximum opening-range trades per day	2
=== 5. Session and execution ===	
First entry hour (server time)	8
No new entries from this hour (server time)	20
Skip entries above this spread (points)	350
Entry method	At market on the signal candle (default)
Maximum lots per trade (0 = no cap)	0.0
Maximum slippage (points)	30
Magic number (change only for a second copy)	26070302
=== 6. Exits ===	
Close part of the trade at the first target	true
First target, as a fraction of the full target	1.00
Portion closed at the first target (%)	50
Move stop to break-even	true
Break-even after this fraction of the target	0.60
Break-even offset (points)	30

OK Cancel Reset

Inputs tab, groups 1–6, with default values.

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Common Inputs

Variable	Value
=== 7. Advanced - strategy tuning (tested defaults, leave unchanged) ===	
Opening range: bars in the range	5
Opening range: timeframe	1 Hour
Entry confirmation timeframe	1 Hour
Reward:risk when no symbol preset applies	1.5
Stop distance in ATR	2.5
Size the stop from volatility (ATR)	true
ATR period	14
Fixed stop buffer if ATR stop is off (points)	80
Minimum range size in ATR	1.50
Skip the day if the range is wider than this in ATR	4.00
Minimum range size if ATR is unavailable (points)	100
Breakout buffer in ATR	0.20
Breakout buffer if ATR is unavailable (points)	50
Breakout candle minimum body (%)	60
Sweep must close back inside the range by (%)	20
Retest zone tolerance (%)	25
Cancel an unfilled signal after this many bars	6
Trade breakouts only with the trend (EMA)	true
Apply the trend filter to sweeps too	true
Trend filter EMA period	50
One trade per strategy per day	true
Stop opening-range trading after a winning trade	true
New York range start hour (server time)	14
New York range bars	2
New York session last entry hour	21
Trend pullback: trend EMA period	200
Trend pullback: pullback EMA period	20
Trend pullback: bars to find the dip	5
Trend pullback: stop beyond the dip (ATR)	0.50
Trend pullback: reward:risk	2.0
=== 8. Display ===	
Show dashboard	true
Draw ranges and signals on the chart	true
Dashboard position X	12
Dashboard position Y	28
Range colour	SteelBlue
Buy colour	LimeGreen
Sell colour	Tomato
Save closed trades to a CSV file	false

OK Cancel Reset

Inputs tab, groups 7–8. Group 7 holds the tested strategy settings — leave them unchanged.

7. Backtest performance

These are hypothetical results from the MetaTrader 5 Strategy Tester, not live trading. They were produced on one broker's data (RoboForex), starting at \$10,000 with 1:100 leverage. Real results depend on your broker's spreads, commission, execution and the market, and will differ. Past performance, simulated or real, does not guarantee future results.

Two test periods were used: **Jan–Aug 2026**, and **the full year 2025**, which was kept aside and never used to choose any setting.

Gold (XAUUSD), DISCIPLINE mode, 1% risk

	Jan–Aug 2026	Full year 2025
Net profit	+\$4,336 (+43%)	+\$4,410 (+44%)
Profit factor	2.14	1.55
Maximum drawdown (balance)	4.9%	4.7%
Win rate	74%	70%
Trades	186	341

Gold, AGGRESSIVE GROWTH mode, 3% risk

	Jan–Aug 2026	Full year 2025
\$10,000 became	\$29,106 (+191%)	\$21,627 (+116%)
Maximum drawdown (balance / equity)	10.6% / 15.6%	20.2% / 22.9%

Gold, FTMO mode, phase 1 (+10% target)

Tested with **real tick data**, one challenge started on each of 12 dates between January 2025 and August 2026, judged against the standard two-step rules (5% daily loss, 10% maximum loss, 4 trading days).

Challenges passed	Challenges failed	Median time to pass	Fastest / slowest	Worst single day
12 of 12	0	38 days	18 / 74 days	–4.06%

Other results

	Jan–Aug 2026	Full year 2025
EURUSD, DISCIPLINE	+\$634	+\$1,296
Gold, HIGH FREQUENCY	+\$1,963 (607 trades)	+\$1,446 (1,119 trades)

Weak periods happen: gold in September 2026 (to the 23rd) was –\$54 in DISCIPLINE mode and –\$181 in GROWTH mode. Silver, GBPUSD and USDJPY lost money in testing and are not recommended.

8. Before you go live

- **Demo first.** Run the EA on a demo account (or a prop firm's free trial) with your broker for at least a few weeks.
- **Only risk money you can afford to lose.** Even with the safety limits, an account can lose up to the configured maximum — 10% in DISCIPLINE mode, 35% in GROWTH mode.
- **Keep the terminal online** (VPS recommended) and do not trade the same symbol manually with the same magic number.
- **Weekend gaps** can jump past a stop. Set FlatBeforeWeekendHour = 21 if you prefer to be flat over the weekend.

Frequently asked questions

Question	Answer
Why no trade today?	Normal. The EA only trades its setups, stops after a winning day in the core strategy, and never opens trades outside the session hours or when the spread is too wide.
The dashboard says PAUSED: DAILY LOSS LIMIT	The day's loss limit was reached. Trading resumes automatically the next day.
The dashboard says HALTED: MAX DRAWDOWN	The account reached its maximum loss limit and the EA has stopped — deliberately, so a person reviews the account first. It remembers the account's peak even after a restart. To resume, press F3 in MT5, delete the variable starting with ADZ11_peak, then attach the EA again.
It says PHASE TARGET HIT	FTMO mode: the target is reached and the EA has stopped. Request your next phase.
Two positions are open	Normal on gold: the opening-range and trend-pullback strategies each hold their own position.
Can I use it on other pairs?	Gold is the main market; EURUSD is supported in DISCIPLINE mode. See the Markets table.
Can I change the settings?	Yes, but the published results only apply to the defaults and the included presets.

Risk warning. Trading foreign exchange and CFDs on margin carries a high level of risk and may not be suitable for all investors. Leverage can work against you as well as for you. You could lose some or all of your deposit. This software is a tool; it does not provide financial advice, and no representation is made that any account will or is likely to achieve profits or losses similar to those shown.